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The Use of Méconnaissance as a Weapon in Oscar Wilde's *The Picture of Dorian Gray*

Oscar Wilde's famous novel *The Picture of Dorian Gray* contains these haunting words in connection with the themes of identity found within: "The picture, changed or unchanged, would be to him the visible emblem of conscience" (Wilde 88). By mirroring Dorian Gray alongside the picture, the reader begins to see how the picture of Dorian Gray is no longer just seen as the symbol of art and beauty visible to both Lord Henry and Basil Howard; it is instead a lens by which to uncover the separation between Dorian Gray's I and me, termed *méconnaissance* by Jacques Lacan (Lacan 1112). By analyzing *The Picture of Dorian Gray* through the lens of the mirror stage by Lacan, the true danger of *méconnaissance* is shown through Dorian Gray. While it may be clearer to show how Dorian Gray has been a victim of *méconnaissance* throughout the novel, by analyzing the beginning mirror moment with Basil Howard, Dorian choosing to hide the portrait, and finally Dorian's eventual death, Dorian emerges not merely as a victim of *méconnaissance* but as an active manipulator who weaponizes his fractured self to justify his immoral actions.

Lacan's mirror stage theory provides the framework for understanding how Dorian Gray molds his fractured self into a weapon. Lacan argues that one of the most formative moments in a young child's life is the moment the child first looks into a mirror and can recognize that the person looking back is themselves (Lacan 1112). This moment forms the contrast between I and me that will be explored in connection with Dorian Gray. While the child believes that the image

in the mirror fully represents themselves, this image does not represent the inner self of the child. This creates what Lacan refers to as the Ideal I or the perceived I that the child sees in the mirror (Lacan 1112). This new understanding of the difference between I and me then causes *méconnaissance* or the separation between the child's image and understanding that it represents themselves versus the reality that this reflection is not who the child is (1112). The image in the mirror is not the child's true inner self, though they may feel that way.

The I/me distinction, articulated by George Herbert Mead, illuminates the specific duplicity Dorian exploits between his fractured inner me and the presented and ideal I. George Herbert Mead, who first defined the usage of the terms I and me in his book *Mind, Self, and Society*, helps to clearly explain the difference between the two. The first term that arises from this mirror moment is the emergence of the I or the self that others can observe. Mead describes I as "The 'I' reacts to the self which arises through the taking of the attitudes of others. The 'I' does not get into the limelight; we talk to ourselves, but do not see ourselves" (Mead 174). However, the I is not a true representation of the self; it is just a visual projection. That true inner self can be found within the second term me, the real and broken version of the self. In helping to explain the use of me, Mead states, "we have introduced the me and we react to it as an I" in order to show the inner expression of me versus the outer expression of I (174). Mead concludes by stating that the child turned adult will spend their entire life trying to reconcile the I with the me (175). Having established these theoretical foundations of the mirror stage and the I/me split, it will now be shown how Dorian Gray will come to exploit this *méconnaissance* for his own personal advantage.

Before his mirror moment, Dorian's carefully maintained innocence serves as the foundation for his later manipulation. At the beginning of the story, Dorian is seen as being

confident in who he is and does not understand fully how he appears to others. However, this childlike innocence of Dorian Gray changes when he views the portrait of himself and understands his new power of using his *méconnaissance* to accomplish his worldly vices. This causes the mirror theory moments that Lacan spoke of. This mirror moment causes the separation of the I and me in Dorian Gray. Throughout the rest of the book, Dorian will spend the rest of the time first focusing on how to reconcile his physical person with the portrait that was created of him and later how to use that separation for his own advantage. This is shown first in the moment of separation of I and me with Dorian seeing the picture for the first time, the moment where Dorian first hides the portrait from the view of other people, and finally when Basil confronts Dorian about the painting at the end of the novel.

At the beginning of *The Picture of Dorian Gray*, Dorian is described as being a young and childlike individual despite being described as a little over twenty years of age. This makes his very essence a performative I as Dorian is showing others an angelic child state while being a young adult in the world. When Lady Brandon refers to Dorian at the beginning of the book, she refers to him as the “Charming boy” (Wilde 9). This perception of Dorian Gray as a child is continued by Basil Howard when he notes that Dorian “has a simple and beautiful nature” and then by Lady Agatha, who states that Dorian is “very earnest with a beautiful nature”(Wilde 15, 14). These childlike depictions have caused Dorian to be described as an angel to the people around him and thought to be painfully innocent to the struggles of the world. This is echoed when the narrator states in relation to Dorian that “One felt that he had kept himself unspotted from the world” (Wilde 17).

This perceived innocent and childlike state is the moment that Basil Howard finds Dorian in and begins to paint his portrait. What will forever be memorialized about Dorian Gray is his

innocent and childlike state, which leads people to feel they can trust and help him (Wilde 7).

This moment, in connection with Lacan's mirror theory, is the moment before the child sees themselves in the mirror (Lacan 1112). Dorian has not yet been fully exposed to how the world views him and has not had the full separation of I and me. Lacan states that this separation can happen at different ages, but they all will have to "recognize as such his own image in a mirror" (Lacan 1112).

The moment Dorian views his completed portrait marks not a full fall into *méconnaissance* but his conscious awakening to the social power this split will grant him. Dorian first remarks to Basil and Lord Henry, "I don't want a life-sized portrait of myself" to avoid the mirror moment that will occur as Dorian comes to actually view himself in relation to other people (Wilde 16). As Lacan has stated, as Dorian sees and accepts himself in the portrait, he will have to accept "the mirror-image . . . to be the threshold of the visible world" (Lacan 1113). Dorian can no longer just see himself as the me he thought he always would be, and as such, he is reluctant to see the painting. Ultimately, Dorian was afraid of the coming truth of the separation of his I and me.

This fear of the separation of Dorian's I and me will not end in tragedy for Dorian but will become a moment when he realizes the power behind his *méconnaissance*. When Dorian saw the painting for the first time, "A look of joy came into his eyes, as if he recognized himself for the first time" (Wilde 25). Dorian now has to see and accept the I of how other people view him, and he is not only pleased by what he sees, but Dorian will come to worship that beautiful I seen in the picture. "A sense of his own beauty came upon him like a revelation" (Wilde 25). For better or for worse, the I for Dorian Gray at the beginning of the novel, and the Dorian Gray that both Lord Henry and Basil Howard idolize as being pure and above the stains of this world, is

now seen clearly by Dorian Gray. This causes the pivotal moment of *méconnaissance* for Dorian as he is viewed as being the best that the world offers in beauty, and as a result, Dorian becomes a muse to Basil, a project to Lord Henry, and an Adonis to himself. As Dorian Gray grows in his understanding of this *méconnaissance*, he will also awake to the reality of how he can use that for his personal benefit.

Dorian Gray's *méconnaissance* does not just create tension at the beginning of the novel, but it will be a driving force that causes the tension throughout the rest of *The Picture of Dorian Gray*. Yan Zhang, author of "From Self-Identification to Self-Destruction: A Mirror Image Interpretation of Dorian Gray's Psychic Transformation", shows this clearly when he states, "In the novel, the portrait plays a role as a carrier combining Dorian's inner world with his outer appearance. It can be regarded as a mirror with magic power on Dorian, through which Dorian forms his self image and loses himself at last. From his ignorance to self-realization to self-destruction, the portrait is one of the most influential elements. To some degree, Dorian's transformation and his fate is inseparably connected to it, even determined by it"(Zhang 4). As Zhang shows in this quote, Dorian's quest for reconciling his I and me will now become inseparably connected to the plot and to Dorian Gray himself. As Dorian moves from "the self-realization to self-destruction", he will first be appalled by the separation, but as he continues to experience the world, Dorian will come to see that separation as a blessing (Zhang 4).

This separation of I and me will lead Dorian Gray to idolize the person of himself in the portrait and initially cause anguish over his inability to reconcile the portrait to himself. Lacan states that "once the image has been mastered and found empty, [it] immediately rebounds" (Lacan 1112). As Dorian looks at the portrait for a moment longer, he realizes "The scarlet would

pass away from his lips, and the gold steel from his hair. The life that was to make his soul would mar his body” (Wilde 25). Here Dorian is realizing that he can never be the I that everyone in the novel sees again, as he leaves behind his previous invisible separation between I and me, and as such notes that “a sharp pang of pain struck through him like a knife” (Wilde 25). Lacan says of those that are painfully unable to reconcile their I and me that it will be “the effect in man of an organic insufficiency in his natural reality” (Lacan 1114).

However, Dorian's initial anguish over his separation gives way to the realization that this split can be exploited as the “sharp pang of pain” quickly gives way to strategic calculation of how Dorian can now hide all of the vices he wants to achieve (Wilde 25). Dorian is realizing here that the I others see will never change, but Dorian’s inner me must change if he wants to seize all of the vices of the world. This *méconnaissance* will lead to Dorian taking the picture from Basil and refusing to let it be shown stating “It will mock me some day — mock me horribly” (27). It is at this point that Dorian makes a bargain: keep being the original beauty that he was at the beginning of the novel (his perceived I) and let the portrait bear the stains of his sins and age (his inner me). Now Dorian has the ability to use the separation of I and me for his own personal advantages without being seen or influenced by those around him.

As Dorian begins to make serious mistakes and hides those mistakes from the people around him, those changes are then reflected in the portrait but not the I that those around Dorian would see. Dorian states of the painting that “It had altered and would alter more” to reflect the greater divide between Dorian’s I and me and Dorian’s growing indifference to his internal separation between I and me growing more distinct (Wilde 88). Just as the child in Lacan’s theory has to eventually grow up and face the impact of their choices on the I and me of their identities, Dorian too is facing a greater separation of I and me as he continues to intentionally

sin (Lacan 1113). The portrait of himself, the I that was originally represented at the beginning of the story, now begins to change into the me for Dorian Gray. It no longer represents the ideal and seen version of Dorian but now reflects the broken and fractured man he has become.

As Dorian gets older, he physically becomes the I that everyone sees as pure and beautiful, while the me represented in the portrait becomes more fractured and disfigured as Dorian continues to sin. Dorian laments, “Why is it that I cannot feel this tragedy as much as I want to?” as he notices this switch within himself (Wilde 96). This shift of the portrait changing from the I to the me manifests when Dorian moves it to the upstairs attic, engaging in what Lacan terms the self-deluding actions that allow the subject to avoid confronting the truth of their existence (Lacan 1115). While before Dorian saw the portrait as “the most magical of mirrors”, he now says that “There is something fatal about a portrait” (Wilde 102, 112). He can no longer pretend to reconcile his I and me, and he worries that the difference between the two will be so stark that all who see his portrait will be able to see the truth. If this occurs, Dorian would be unable to continue to use the *méconnaissance* for his advantage socially and morally. Dorian now “could not run the risk of such a discovery again . . . in a room to which any of his friends had access” (112). Dorian then uses this hiding of the image and his *méconnaissance* to his advantage to finally be able to give in to worldly vices without punishment. Dorian no longer must reconcile his inner self or be socially punished for his lack, and as a direct result, he now begins to weaponize his *méconnaissance*.

With the portrait safely hidden, Dorian can now use his perceived I as a shield, knowingly engaging in vices while his unchanging appearance deflects all suspicion. This hiding of the portrait works for nearly two decades, and Dorian now “would often adopt certain modes of thought that he knew to be really alien to his nature” as he is no longer forced by other people

to reconcile his I and me (Wilde 126-127). This leads Dorian to callousness over Sibyl Vane's suicide, influencing other young men to get entrapped in gambling, and to his own personal vice of opium. While Dorian is now capable of making significant mistakes without it affecting how he looks physically, in the back of his mind is always the understanding that the portrait of himself is changing to reflect these moments of indulgence. This causes Dorian to become impulsive in his returning back to the portrait to analyze it without any other people seeing his actions (117). While Dorian is now capable of hiding his *méconnaissance* to the people around him and to achieve the worldly pleasures he sought for, he will start to feel a greater widening of his I and me as a direct result. Although this *méconnaissance* of his I and me is letting Dorian Gray make moral failings without social punishment, he still can not escape his own broken self reflected in the picture.

This constant returning to the portrait is indicative of Dorian's deep desire to reconcile his I and me, despite other people no longer playing a key role in making that reconciliation happen. While at the beginning of the novel every time Dorian tries to reconcile the I and me between him and his portrait he is always surrounded by other people, by the end of *The Picture of Dorian Gray*, every attempt to reconcile the I and the me is now a private affair for Dorian. It is no longer the visible anguish depicted at the beginning of the book but a slow destruction of Dorian's being. Lacan echoes this when he said that "Freedom is never more authentic than when it is within the walls of a prison" (Lacan 1116); Dorian is now exercising the self delusion that the child in the mirror theory feels when seeing themselves for the first time (freedom) but is unable to feel yet their inner me (prison) limitations (1112). In the final moments before Dorian kills Basil, Basil states to Dorian that "You told me you had destroyed it" speaking of the original and public attempts to deal with the painting, and as an extent, the public viewing

Dorian's I and me (Wilde 150). In response, Dorian states, "I was wrong. It has destroyed me" showing how the attempted reconciliation between himself as the I and his portrait as the me has led to a private destruction of Dorian's inner self regardless of the worldly pleasures that it gave him along the way as he weaponized that *méconnaissance* (150).

This inability to truly reconcile Dorian's I and me comes because reconciling his I and me is not Dorian's true *objet petit a*. *Objet petit a*, as defined by Lacan, is the true desire that an individual wants but can never fully achieve. Within Lacan's "Seminar XI: The Four Fundamental Concepts of Psychoanalysis", he states, "The *objet a* is something from which the subject, in order to constitute itself, has separated itself off as organ. This serves as a symbol of the lack" (Lacan 259). While it might appear at first to readers that Dorian's *objet petit a* is to reconcile his I and me between him and the portrait, that is not the case. Right after Dorian sees his own portrait for the first time, he exclaims that he wishes he can be young and beautiful forever. While this wish is granted, Dorian is still never satisfied with how beautiful he is. Dorian is constantly comparing himself with the image in the portrait to see how far he has fallen from his original beauty with "finely curved scarlet lips, his frank blue eyes, and his crisp gold hair" and how to achieve that state again (Wilde 17). This desire for beauty at all costs is Dorian Gray's true *objet petit a*, and as such, he will never be able to fully reclaim that beauty and reconcile his I and Me. It is no surprise then that Dorian decides to use his *méconnaissance* for his gain, while knowing and feeling that he can never actually achieve the *objet petit a* of eternal beauty that he desires.

In speaking of this struggle with reconciliation to his *objet petit a*, Christopher Craft wrote in his essay "Come See About Me: Enchantment in the Double of *The Picture of Dorian Gray*" about the different versions of Dorian Gray that arise as he sees himself mirrored in the

portrait and strives to the ultimate beauty that Dorian can not achieve. Craft states, “Despite “Dorian’s” indignation at “the other” Dorians, the “original” here can aspire only to be acknowledged as the privileged copy or authentic substitute. First among the latecomers, he alone would deserve to inherit the aura of the nonexistent but now deceased “original of the portrait.” At the busy seat of identity, then, Wilde discloses image-theft, mimetic proliferation, and the enchantment of the double” (Craft 24). Craft's insight illuminates Dorian's impossible predicament: the living Dorian can never be the “original” because that original I exists only as artistic representation. He is forever a copy of that Ideal I, striving to reconcile his inner me to that moment, creating what Craft calls “mimetic proliferation” or multiple inauthentic Dorians competing to become his true self. This “image-theft” makes reconciliation between I and me once again impossible, as every attempt to embody the portrait's beauty only emphasizes the gap between Dorian’s objet petit a and his reality. Dorian now weaponizes a self that can never be authentic because the “original” I exists only in artistic representation.

Dorian's final act of destroying the portrait exposes the fatal limitation of weaponized méconnaissance: the split self he exploited for decades cannot be eliminated without eliminating his full self. All of these small moments of méconnaissance in the course of Dorian Gray’s life lead to the end of *The Picture of Dorian Gray* when Dorian ends up stabbing the portrait of himself in a vain attempt to finally reconcile his I and me. Lacan states in attempting to reconcile the I and me that “every instinctual thrust constitutes a danger, even though it should correspond to natural maturation” (Lacan 115). Without the ability to reconcile his I and me and seeing how people are slowly beginning to notice his vices, Dorian decides to take the only action that he feels is within his power. In the process, Dorian destroys the me, his innermost fractured and broken self that is symbolized in the portrait. This causes the ending reconciliation that Dorian

has been striving for since his first mirror moment of seeing the portrait Basil had painted.

However, this also causes Dorian's death as the beauty of his I is destroyed and taken over by the age and brokenness of his me.

Just as Dorian feared, he would never achieve his object petit a of a perfect and ageless beauty, and in his vain attempts to first reconcile the I and me and the later attempts to hide the méconnaissance, Dorian did not achieve either his object petit a, his desired reconciliation, or his full manipulation of the méconnaissance. By the end of the story, the servants who find the body of Dorian Gray find an ugly shriveled corpse with a knife stabbed into the heart and note that he was "withered, wrinkled, and loathsome of visage" (Wilde 214). In the end, although Dorian originally mentioned "how pleased he used to be when he was pointed out, stared at, or talked about" by all the people around him, the servants are left unable to recognize their master by anything besides his ring (Wilde 210, 214). This destruction of Dorian Gray at the end of *The Picture of Dorian Gray* leaves a final question: who is responsible for the destruction of Dorian Gray?

Basil Howard, as the painter of the portrait and self-proclaimed first person to truly see who Dorian Gray truly is, may be the first responsible for Dorian's downfall. This is because Basil Howard fills both Lacan's terms of being the Other and the Gaze throughout the novel. Lacan first describes the Other as the position from which the individual is judged, observed, and understood (Lacan 1112). Throughout the novel, Basil Howard does not just see the I that Dorian Gray is showing others in his physical appearance but also the me of who Dorian truly is, a fractured and broken man. This, however, causes Basil to also become the Gaze, Lacan's term for the sense of being seen from the outside and keeps the original individual from truly expressing themselves (Feldstein 139). The Gaze, in Lacanian terms, represents the anxiety of

being constituted by another's look, of becoming an object rather than a subject, which Dorian is beginning to experience through the eyes of Basil. For Dorian, Basil's vision sees both the beautiful I and the corrupt me simultaneously. This creates unbearable tension: Dorian can perform his beauty for the world and hide the inner me, but Basil's gaze pierces through the performatory I to Dorian's truest me, the broken and vile man he has become. Within the logic of *méconnaissance*, Basil's murder becomes psychologically necessary and the only way to eliminate the sole person who can see the truth of Dorian's fractured self. As long as Basil Howard exists, Dorian can not use the *méconnaissance* to his advantage as there is a man that can see right through him.

Because Dorian Gray knows that Basil can see him as he truly is, despite his actions first to reconcile the I and me and then to weaponize that *méconnaissance*, Dorian Gray is held captive by the gaze of Basil Howard. Dorian understands how Basil must expect him to be and be seen, and as such, he mirrors this in his actions towards the world and Basil especially. However, this strain of Basil's gaze on the already fractured state between Dorian's I and me will eventually take Dorian to ending the life of Basil Howard.

However, as opposed to Dorian seeing this failing as a deficit, he will continue to use his *méconnaissance* from the beginning of *The Picture of Dorian Gray* to the end of the novel to accomplish his aims. While Basil was instrumental in showing Dorian the I of himself that other people see, Dorian was already becoming aware of himself and his influence and appearance to others by the time that Basil showed him the portrait. Basil remarks at the beginning of *The Picture of Dorian Gray* that "I am afraid that I have shown in it the secret of my soul" to both Dorian and the portrait (Wilde 7). As Dorian is aware of Basil bearing his soul, he continues to manipulate Basil to the point that Basil remarks of Dorian, "He is absolutely necessary to me",

and that Basil had “always been his own master; had at least always been so, till [he] met Dorian Gray”(11, 8). If Dorian was unaware of the way he impacted people, he would not have been unable to influence Basil in the way that he did. While Dorian’s true mirror moment would come later in the novel, Dorian is becoming prepared for the reality of his later *méconnaissance* from the beginning of the story and already preparing to use it for his gain. Before ever seeing the portrait, Dorian has already reduced Basil to a state of utter dependence, transforming an established artist into someone who confesses Dorian is “absolutely necessary” to him (11). This manipulation reveals a beginning awareness of his own effect on others that comes before Dorian Gray ever came face to face with his portrait. The ways that he was treating other people, based off of his internal and fractured me, were already deviating from Dorian’s I, the seen and assumed angelic version of Dorian. Thus, Dorian was already becoming self-aware and beginning his journey to use his physical and psychological separation of I and me long before Basil ever met him.

The second character that may be responsible for the destruction of Dorian Gray is Lord Henry. At the beginning of the story, Lord Henry was right there when the separation of Dorian’s I and me occurred. As opposed to Basil who tried to comfort and protect Dorian from the dangers of the world, Lord Henry instead tries to pollute Dorian by helping Dorian to choose a life of sin and pleasure. Lord Henry is said to have “such a beautiful voice” and “really a very bad influence”, which he directly uses to influence Dorian for the majority of the novel (Wilde 18). Yet if Lord Henry merely holds up the mirror to show Dorian of who he could be in a world of vice, what of the voice speaking of the virtue and necessities of beauty into Dorian's ear as he gazes into it?

Even after Dorian had separated from Lord Henry by the end of the novel and started choosing to be better, Dorian was still failing and hurting the people around him. Dorian remarks to Lord Henry that “I am not going to have the same life” showing his desire to reconcile himself and aim for a higher way of living that would be “like the converted” (Wilde 208, 209).

However, when Lord Henry leaves, Dorian begins to spurn a girl that he had convinced to love him (210). Thus, Lord Henry’s impact was not the key influence in the failing of Dorian Gray because even when Lord Henry was not influencing him, Dorian still sinned. The persistence of Dorian's corruption beyond Lord Henry's direct influence suggests a deeper look past the moral degradation of the people around Dorian Gray but to the *méconnaissance* within Dorian himself.

Ultimately, the destruction of Dorian’s I and me is placed solely on the head of Dorian Gray and his attempts to weaponize his *méconnaissance*. This is shown beautifully from this final comment by Lacan, who said, “The sufferings of neurosis and psychosis are for us a schooling in the passions of the soul” and that the madness which comes from separating the I and me will be the “madness that deafens the world with its sound and fury”(Lacan 1117). Lacan here is showing that in using *méconnaissance* for an individual’s gain, like in the case of Dorian Gray, will lead to madness and fury. Phillipe Givre continues to echo this destruction of self that occurred to Dorian Gray in his article “Dorian Gray’s Perverted Portraits and Mirrors”. As Givre observes, Dorian's “narcissistic splitting” initially appears to offer salvation but ultimately “deprives him of an essential part of his very being” (Givre 7). This deprivation of his self, both of the I and me, however, is not merely inflicted upon Dorian. It is actively maintained by him as a convenient tool to use whenever he decides to slip morally from what is deemed socially acceptable. What begins as an innocent awakening of Dorian’s I and me becomes a deliberate

shield and weapon, allowing Dorian to externalize all moral consequences while preserving his beautiful facade.

While Dorian Gray's attempts, after the first mirror moment at the beginning of the novel, show how he first tried to accept then use his *méconnaissance*, this ultimately led to his downfall, as seen by his self-destruction at the end of the book. In trying in vain to obtain his *objet petit a* of permanent and lasting beauty, Gray causes a greater separation between the I and me than ever before. Dorian then uses this *méconnaissance* to hide his true faults from the people around him and use the picture and his severed self to his own advantage. Hence, Dorian Gray is not just the victim seen at the beginning of the novel with his "simple and beautiful nature" but now an active manipulator of his own severed self who continually "had enticed many into debauchery and degradation" (Wilde 15, 135).

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